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Sudan, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Central African Republic

Section Title(S)

9 SANZA , A CHARACTERISTIC FEATURE OF ZANDE LANGUAGE AND THOUGHT 1956

(14) A commoner may speak or act a *sanza* towards a prince, but unless it is an entirely harmless joking kind of *sanza* or a highly complimentary one he runs a grave risk in doing so. A harmless *sanza*, what Azande call a *sanza mbaro*, a *sanza* in fun, is the habit of old commoner favourites of a prince of placing their hands before their mouths when speaking, especially when beginning to speak to him. This is a playful introduction to what a man is about to say. An insulting *sanza* to a prince in the old days might have been severely punished, even if the man who said it belonged to the aristocratic class and was therefore a kinsman of the prince. Gangura son of Gbudwe emasculated Mbitiyo son of Badiya, because he said 'the red duiker will eat ground-nuts'. This animal does not eat ground-nuts. I was never able to understand what precisely the allusion to the red duiker meant, but I was told that what was implied in the words was 'your country will become poor and you will lose your province'. Mbitiyo had been given a small part of the province to administer by Gangura, but he was dissatisfied with it.

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(15) Another story told about Gangura is a literal application of the proverb *i na ni nga ku rogo kuru guga te* 'one does not excrete into an old water-hole'. The story is that 'there was a man called Ngawe who was a subject of Gangura. Ngawe said that Gangura was no good as a ruler. He arose and went home and when he had arrived there he excreted in his granary, in his huts, and into his water-hole also. He then departed to go to Basongoda's country. While he was in Basongoda's country the sons of Narepa of the Akpura clan showed themselves hostile to him, saying to him 'you killed our father Narepa with sorcery, and he died. Why have you  219 come back again among us? What happened to you in Gangura's country?'. Ngawe fled back to Gangura's country. When he had arrived there Gangura told him to go and live in his deserted home and clean up his water-hole which he had excreted into; if he made another new home he, Gangura, would drive him away. Ngawe went and resided in his old homestead where he had polluted the place and drank from that same water-hole he had excreted into. Thus people say "do not in

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departing dirty your old water-hole" '. Ngawe had polluted his home as a *sanza*, to show his contempt for Gangura and that he was going for good. But one never knows what future circumstances may determine. That is the meaning of the proverb.

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